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Article Summary

Semaglutide is a glucagon-like peptide-1 (GLP-1) analogue. It was originally studied for type 2 diabetes treatment, administered with a prefilled pen injector. In that study, a surprising finding showed that this drug had weight loss effect among participants with type 2 diabetes and heart disease. Thus, a new global study was initiated to see if a weekly dose of 2.4 mg of semaglutide could help people with obesity or overweight lose weight, combining with healthy lifestyle changes. The treatment lasted 68 weeks followed by a 7-week observation. The enrolled 1961 participants were 18+ years old adults who failed to lose weight with the dietary efforts. These participants have either a body mass index (BMI, the weight in kilograms divided by the square of the height in meters) of 30 or greater, or a BMI of 27 or greater with weight-related coexisting conditions. The participants were divided into the semaglutide and placebo groups at a 2:1 ratio, the latter of which did not receive active treatment. The outcomes were measured by metrics like body weight, physical composition, self-reporting physical functioning data, and lipid levels. The main finding of the study was that the semaglutide group achieved a weight loss of -14.9% (-15.3 kg) at week 68, and in the placebo group it was -2.4% (-2.6 kg). 86.4% of the semaglutide group lost weight by at least 5% compared to 31.5% of the placebo group. People taking semaglutide also showed greater improvement in health factors related to the heart disease and diabetes and reported greater improvements in their ability to perform daily physical activities. Nausea and diarrhea were common symptoms, typically mild to moderate and temporary. About 4.5% of people taking semaglutide stopped treatment because of stomach or digestive problems, compared with 0.8% receiving placebo. In conclusion, for adults with overweight or obesity, 2.4 mg of semaglutide once weekly plus healthy lifestyle changes resulted in greater weight loss than lifestyle changes with placebo over 68 weeks.